



Boom-time city

Unlike the other Emirates, Dubai's wealth is not historically dependent on oil revenues. As service industries develop, construction of prestige high-rise developments continues to boom.

UAE



The oil-rich Emirates have developed rapidly over the past 30 years, but remain autocratic regimes.

1820 The area becomes known as the Trucial Coast after the UK signs a treaty with local rulers to combat piracy.

1892 Deal between Trucial States and UK: each emirate controls internal affairs while the UK controls foreign policy.

1952 The seven emirates come together in the Trucial Council.

1959 Significant oil strikes in the region.

1968 Bahrain and Qatar join the Trucial States, only to leave three years later.

1971 The UK withdraws as protecting power and the UAE federation is formed, comprising Abu Dhabi, Ajman, Dubai, Fujairah, Sharjah, and Umm al-Qaywayn. Sheikh Zayed Bin-Sultan Al Nahayyan presides over the federation.

1972 Ras al-Khaymah joins the federation.

1987 Failed coup in Sharjah.

1991 UAE offers bases to the West after Kuwait is invaded. BCCI bank, owned by Abu Dhabi's ruling family, collapses.

1993 Immigrants from Asia and Africa now three-quarters of the population.

2000 Sharia law is introduced in Fujairah and an Indonesian woman is sentenced to be stoned to death.

2004 Sheikh Zayed dies and is replaced by his son, Sheikh Khalifa.

2006 The UAE holds its first-ever national elections, with the franchise limited to a hand-picked electorate. They elect half the members of the Federal National Council, an advisory body.

2009 The international financial crisis causes the UAE to withdraw from the planned Gulf Monetary Union. The government-owned conglomerate Dubai World almost collapses. Only \$4.1 billion bailout from Abu Dhabi saves it.

2010 The Burj Khalifa tower opens in Dubai as the world's tallest building.

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Bahrain



This island state in the Persian Gulf has diversified from oil into financial services.

1521 The Portuguese assume control.

1602 Persia occupies Bahrain.

1783 The Iranians are expelled by the Arabian Utub tribe, whose principal family, the al-Khalifas, still rule today.

1861 The ruling sheikh of Bahrain agrees to abstain from war, piracy, and slavery in return for British military support.

1880 Administrative control and foreign relations are granted to the UK.

1913 UK and the Ottoman Empire sign a treaty recognizing Bahrain's independence.

1931 Oil is discovered in Bahrain, and extraction begins a year later.

1939 The British decide that the Hawar Islands belong to Bahrain and not Qatar.

1967 The UK relocates its naval base in the region from Aden to Bahrain. The following year, it announces its intention to close all bases "east of Suez" by 1971.

1971 Independence from Britain under Sheikh Isa Bin-Salman Al Khalifah.

1975 Emir dissolves the National Assembly and rules by decree.

1981 Founding member of GCC.

1990–91 Bahrain supports UN action expelling Iraq from Kuwait.

1994–96 Shia unrest.

1999 Accession to throne of Sheikh Hamad bin Isa al-Khalifa.

2001 Transition to democracy. Bahrain becomes a constitutional monarchy with an elected lower chamber of parliament.

2002 Parliamentary elections are held for the first time in 30 years.

2006 Shia opposition wins 40 percent of votes in election. Jawad bin Salem al Oraied, a Shia, becomes prime minister.

2010 Twenty Shia political leaders are arrested, accused of plotting to overthrow the Bahraini monarchy.

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Qatar



A former center of pearl fishing that has been transformed by the discovery of oil.

1700s Pearlring and trading settlements are established along the coast.

1867 Doha is all but destroyed in a conflict with neighboring Bahrain. The UK recognizes Qatar as a separate entity from Bahrain.

1939 Oil reserves are discovered but exploitation is delayed by World War II. Post-war, oil quickly replaces pearling and fishing as Qatar's main source of income.

1971 Independence from the UK.

1972 Accession of Amir Khalifa, who deposes his father.

1995 Sheikh Hamad overthrows his father Shaikh Khalifa in a bloodless coup.

1996 Satellite TV channel Al-Jazeera, a news channel, is launched. Funded by the emir, it broadcasts to much of the Arab world, providing an Arab perspective on world affairs.

1999 First-ever polls, to elect new municipal council, mark the beginning of a program of democratization.

2000 Thirty-three rebels are sentenced to life imprisonment for their part in the failed 1996 coup. Among them is the emir's cousin, an ally of the emir's deposed father.

2001 Long-standing border disputes with Saudi Arabia and Bahrain are settled.

2004 Relations with Russia deteriorate when former Chechen president Zelimkhan Yanderbiyev is killed in an explosion in Doha.

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Kuwait



A small oil-producing kingdom surrounded by large and powerful neighbors.

750–1258 The Abbasid Caliphate of Baghdad controls Kuwait.

1258–1546 Kuwait under Mongol rule.

1546–1918 Ottomans govern Kuwait.

1756 Al-Sabah ruling dynasty is founded.

1899 Sheikh Mubarak grants the UK control of the country's foreign relations.

1918 Ottoman Empire dismantled. Kuwait becomes a British protectorate. New Iraqi state makes first claims over Kuwait.

1938 Oil extraction begins.

1961 Independence from UK.

1976 Emir suspends National Assembly.

1990 Iraq invades, starting the Gulf War.

1991 An international coalition led by the US forces the Iraqis to withdraw, but oil wells are set aflame and no oil can be produced until 1992. Under international pressure, the emir promises democratic reforms.

1992 National Assembly elections held.

1994 Iraq recognizes Kuwait's sovereign status.

2003 The roles of prime minister and heir to throne are separated for first time since independence. Islamist candidates make gains in general election.

2006 Women are able to vote for parliament for the first time.

2006 Sheikh Saber dies and is succeeded by Sheikh Sabah al-Ahmed.

2008 Radical Islamists win more than half the seats in general election.

«80–81 Rulers of the Iron Age
«468–69 The Gulf Wars



Fields of fire

Here Kuwaiti oil fields set aflame by retreating Iraqi troops blacken the sky with smoke. About 50 oil wells were lit after the 1990 Iraqi invasion. The cost of the clean up ran into billions of dollars.